

CEDAR GROVE SCHOOL

Family *Handbook*

2026 – 2027

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www.cedargroveschool.ca

Contents

Welcome

Welcome to Cedar Grove School

Vision

Mission

Our Core Values

School Code

Administrative Information

Faculty and Administration

Office Hours

Morning Drop-Off

Afternoon Pick-Up

Professional Activity & Conference Days

Inclement Weather and School Closure

Cedar Grove Programs

Kindergarten / Grade One Program

Rhythms

Grade School Program

Grade School Classroom Guidelines

Food

Festivals

Birthdays

Field Trips

Health, Safety and Development

Health, Safety and Development

Illness and Attendance Guidelines

Guidelines for Gear and Clothing

Electronics and Media

Community

Communication and Culture

Parent-School Communication

WELCOME

Welcome to Cedar Grove School

The Cedar Grove School Faculty and Staff extend a warm welcome to all families. We respect the trust that you have shown us by placing your child in our school and look forward to working together for the benefit of your child.

We envision our independent and community-based school to flourish with the participation of generations of new families who offer diverse ideas, skills and experiences. Parents, guardians, and extended community members build and sustain the fabric of our school. Each family's participation is welcome and essential to the continued strength of our community. Here are a few of the possibilities for involvement:

Enhance your child's classroom experience

Parents/guardians and extended family members are welcome to help with various classroom tasks like laundry and minor repairs, and to work with the teacher to share a celebration or festival, and/or share knowledge and experience in support of the class curriculum in many different areas. Please see parent participation form for more information.

Join an intentional and collaborative community

Parents/guardians are welcome to all social events. Getting involved is a great way to get to know other families, teachers, and the wider community. Most importantly, our students sense the meaning and sense of belonging that comes with their parents', guardians', or extended family members' contribution to the school.

VISION

To return childhood to nature. We envision a world where learning is joyful, soulful and grounded in community and place. Where children are free to explore, create and grow at their own rhythm, guided by mentors who honour their individuality and uphold the integrity of each developmental phase. We seek to cultivate a generation of socially conscious, environmentally attuned and compassionately engaged human beings.

MISSION

We provide holistic, nature-based education that honours the sacred unfolding of childhood. Inspired by Waldorf traditions, our programs nurture the full spectrum of human development, head, heart and hands, through imaginative, experiential and relationship-rich learning. We support children in becoming capable, creative, resilient individuals who are connected to the land, themselves and one another.

Our Core Values

1 Reverence for Childhood

2 Developmentally-Aligned Learning

3 Nature as Teacher

4 Whole Child Approach

5 Relationships at the Centre

6 Inclusion and Belonging

7 Screen-Free, Human-Centred Learning

8 Artistic, Experiential Pedagogy

9 Community Life and Festival Culture

School Code

Respect ourselves, respect others, and respect our environment. We show our respect through inclusion, kindness, and responsibility.

Faculty and Administration

A very warm welcome to Cedar Grove School from the Faculty of 2026–2027:

Kerri Smart	Lead Kindergarten Teacher	kerri@cedargroveschool.ca
Henry Lear	Lead Grade School Teacher	henry@cedargroveschool.ca
Jasmin Wakeling	Assistant Teacher	jasmin@cedargroveschool.ca
Sara Benedict	Music Teacher	

The Administration of Cedar Grove School also welcomes you:

Kelly Purves	Administrative Assistant	kelly@cedargroveschool.ca
Marissa Norton	Head of School	marissa@cedargroveschool.ca
Claire Telford	Co-Founder / Operational Support	claire@cedargroveschool.ca

Office Hours

The school is open from 8:30am to 3:30pm, Monday to Friday. We look forward to keeping in touch with parents/guardians and community members in person, by telephone or by email. In-person meetings are by appointment only. Enquiries may be directed in either of the following ways:

GETTING IN TOUCH

For pedagogical enquiries: marissa@cedargroveschool.ca

For all other enquiries: admin@cedargroveschool.ca

Phone: (343) 309-5890

Arrival & Departure

8:40 am

MORNING DROP-OFF

3:30 pm

AFTERNOON PICK-UP

Morning Drop-Off

Please park in the parking lot at the school entrance next to County Road 15 and walk your child down the winding trail to the school for sign in at 8:40 am. This walk provides the children the opportunity for movement and to breathe and experience nature before entering the school.

Attendance is confirmed with the office at 9:15am. Parents will receive a phone call if their child is absent or late without notice.

ABSENCE OR LATENESS

Please phone the Office at **(343) 309-5890** if your child will be absent or late.

Strive to make your goodbye routine consistent and simple. Say your goodbye to your child, then take a moment to share a smile and a "hello" with the teacher. It is important that the children see their parents/guardians and teachers greeting one another warmly. Trust the teachers to guide your child through the goodbye once you have said you are leaving. **Rest assured that if your child experiences prolonged upset over separation, we will contact you.**

Please contact the Lead Teacher if you feel that goodbyes are a challenge. We will be happy to find ways to support you and your child in this process.

Afternoon Pick-Up

Please park in the parking lot at the school entrance next to County Road 15. This will allow you to walk with your child down the winding trail at the end of the day. This walk provides the children the opportunity for movement and to tell you about their day, experiencing nature before entering your vehicle.

Please ensure children are picked up promptly at 3:30 at the school building. The time after dismissal is a valuable work period for educators to complete planning, preparation, and other important tasks that cannot be done while they are caring for and teaching the children.

PLEASE REMEMBER

To ensure the safety of all students, please supervise your child once they are dismissed from their teacher's care. Playground rules continue to apply after dismissal.

At pick-up and drop-off, teachers are supervising children and are unavailable for in-depth discussions. You may use email or a written note to schedule a time to speak with your child's teacher by phone or in person.

It is a legal requirement that each child be signed in and out each day by the teachers.

A Special Note about the First Days for Kindergarten Students

We appreciate that for some children this will be the first day in a new class and/or the first time away from home. Your child will become comfortable with the teachers and the group more easily if goodbyes are heartfelt and brief. If you find goodbyes are challenging for your child, it is helpful to say goodbye and depart without lingering, especially during the first month of school.

Calendar & Closures

Professional Activity and Parent/Guardian-Teacher Conference Days

There are two Parent/Guardian-Teacher Conferences scheduled on Professional Activity days. There will be no regular classes on PA Days. Please refer to the calendar on www.cedargroveschool.ca for dates.

Please note: Parent/Guardian-Teacher Conferences are for those students attending 4–5 days.

Inclement Weather and School Closure

Cedar Grove School will be closed when travelling conditions are extremely hazardous or in the event of unsafe conditions at the school (prolonged power outage, water stoppage, etc).

All efforts will be made to send an email communication by 7:30 a.m that morning. We urge parents/guardians to exercise caution when making the decision to drive to school. Depending on attendance and staffing, groups may be combined and alternative programming may be offered.

If weather conditions become worse during the course of the day, parents/guardians will be called to pick up their child(ren) early. The safety of families and staff is our primary concern.

Our Programs

Because Nature as Teacher is a core value of Cedar Grove School, outdoor learning and exploration are essential pillars of our curriculum.

Our goal is to spend as much time outside as possible, whether for structured academic activities or unstructured play. Depending on the season and the activity at hand, outdoor time can range from a minimum of 2 hours during the coldest months to full days spent outside in more temperate weather.

Kindergarten / Grade One Program

The Cedar Grove Kindergarten/Grade One program fosters the natural curiosity and wonder of children ages four through seven by providing a beautiful and caring environment. Through a carefully unified program of structured activities and creative play, the children are given full scope to unfold their creative and imaginative faculties.

Simple toys stimulate the child's imagination to create an endless variety of play scenarios both indoors and out. Time outdoors in nature, painting, singing, oral storytelling, beeswax modelling, drawing, gardening, puppetry, play acting, woodworking, baking, circles games, handwork and unstructured play are all a part of the rhythm.

These essential developmental activities foster the young child's natural aptitude in oral literacy and numeracy and lay a strong foundation for literacy and numeracy.

Rhythms

Children thrive when their days are predictable and balanced. Just like the natural rhythms we all experience of waking and sleeping, eating meals, or the changing seasons; a steady rhythm in the classroom helps young children feel secure, enabling them to fully engage in the present activity or play.

In our Kindergarten/Grade One class, we structure the day with a thoughtful flow between active and quiet moments. Our daily Rhythm includes: plenty of energetic outdoor play, a restful break, creative indoor play, focussed group activities and practical tasks. Children are invited to take part in daily classroom tasks, building a sense of responsibility and community.

Transitions are gently guided with a song or a familiar routine so children move from one activity to the next with ease. This daily rhythm provides consistency and supports the healthy development of attention, imagination, and social skills.

The grade one students will work on their main lesson while the Kindergarten students enjoy a period of free play in the shared space.

Grade School Program

Rhythm is of central importance to the nourishment and orientation of students. Our Waldorf inspired curriculum follows a rhythm, which builds successively through each subject block, usually three to four weeks long. There is an academic and social momentum that builds for the whole group of students within a class. Together they become engaged in the subject through listening to stories, artistic activities and group discussions. Cedar Grove programs follow daily, weekly and yearly patterns.

Guidelines & Traditions

Attendance

Students receive a rigorous academic and experiential curriculum which is integrated with art, music and movement. In order to benefit from the full curriculum and become part of the social fabric of the class and school community, your child's participation in all parts of the day is important. Please help your child to arrive on time at school (at 8:40am). Late arrivals are disruptive to the class community and cause students to miss warm up activities that are important to building social relationships and reinforcing academic learning.

Absences interrupt the learning experience for the student who is away as well as for the rest of the class. Please notify the Office and your child's teacher of any planned extended absences.

Food

Our school supports the belief that what we eat and drink has a profound effect on the health of our bodies. If your child is on a special diet, please notify the teacher. Advise the Office and teacher of all allergies or health issues.

All students are to bring their own lunches and water from home. Please provide plenty of simple and wholesome food for your child. We strive to have litter-free lunches — garbage and compost will be sent home.

Festivals

Festivals are based on the season or a cultural celebration. As the year weaves from one festival to another, we are provided with the opportunity for joyful preparation and a true reason for celebration. For the young child, preparation is half the joy. They love discovering the classroom decorations, baking special treats and learning songs and verses chosen just for that particular festival.

Parents/guardians are encouraged to support the planning and implementation of the festivals through the Festival Committee. Interested parents can connect with the Festival Committee Chair.

Birthdays

Birthday celebrations bring a wondrous glow that surrounds the children. The teachers regard your child's presence as a blessing and are grateful for the opportunity to express appreciation on their birthday. Please share any considerations about celebrating your child at school with the teacher. Our school celebrations include all of the children in the class, please inform the Head of School if your family does not celebrate birthdays.

Please note: if you are having a celebration at home that does not include everyone in the class, please hand invitations directly to parents/guardians as a way of avoiding awkwardness or hurt feelings.

Field Trips

The Kindergarten class currently does not have any field trips planned, however, 1–2 trips may be scheduled as the year unfolds. Should we integrate field trips into the year, you will be given advanced notice.

Keeping Children Well

Dietary and allergy restrictions should be communicated to us so that necessary adjustments can be made. The Head of School and Lead Teacher must be advised of all allergies and medical issues and updated as soon as possible if there are changes.

Staff will not generally administer medication, unless previously detailed on the Health and Emergency information form. On an "exception only" basis, medicine prescribed by a physician in the original container may be administered. The parents must notify the Head of School in advance and the proper forms must be signed.

All classroom volunteers (including parents/guardians, grandparents, and teacher candidates) whose roles involve being left alone to supervise children must provide the school with a copy of a current (within 6 months) Vulnerable Sector Check, and provide a copy to keep on file in the school Office. If you anticipate volunteering in this capacity, please email admin@cedargroveschool.ca for a letter requesting this check well in advance, as it can take multiple weeks to receive.

Cedar Grove School strives to provide a healthy environment for students, staff and families. To avoid many common illnesses, teach children HOW and WHEN to wash their hands properly: wash regularly before eating and after using the toilet or blowing your nose.

Illness and Attendance Guidelines

Please phone the Office at **(343) 309-5890** if your child will be late or absent.

When a student becomes ill during the day, parents/guardians will be contacted to make arrangements for their child to be taken home if the symptoms:

- Prevent the student from participating comfortably in program activities
- May be contagious

Please keep in mind that lively classrooms are not a soothing environment for a student who is not well. Please keep your child home when they are exhibiting symptoms of illness to prevent germs from spreading through the class.

Keep your child home if any of the following are present

- **Unusual behaviour:** including extreme lethargy or irritability, persistent crying, difficulty breathing, or other signs of possible illness.
- **Diarrhea:** An episode of diarrhea within the past 24 hours. Children should stay home until symptom-free for 24 hours.
- **Vomiting:** An episode of vomiting during the previous 24 hours. Children should stay home until symptom-free for 24 hours.
- **Fever:** Children should stay home until fever-free without medication for 24 hours.
- **Rash:** A rash appearing with fever or behaviour change. Exclusion from school should continue until the child is evaluated by a healthcare professional. (See Impetigo)

- **Impetigo:** Highly contagious. Exclusion from school should continue until the child is evaluated by a healthcare professional.
- **Pinworms:** Notify school if there is any possibility of pinworms as it is highly contagious. Children must be finished treatment before returning to school to avoid an outbreak.
- **Lice:** Notify school if there is any suspicion of head lice as it is highly contagious. Children should be treated before returning to school to avoid an outbreak.
- **Pink Eye:** Highly contagious. Children must be finished treatment before returning to school to avoid an outbreak.

Gear & Clothing

Please label all clothing, gear, and personal items.

The classrooms and yards are places of active work and play. Based on our experience, we offer the following guidelines to ensure that your child is comfortable, safe, and fully able to participate in all our activities.

Where possible, for all clothing and accessories (e.g., lunch bags, backpacks, hats), we ask that you choose items that are free of distractions (e.g., items that are free of brands and commercial images). More on this in the Electronics and Media section below.

Outerwear and Gear

To allow your child to experience nature and the elements in an enjoyable, comfortable way, clothing is extremely important. Please provide:

- A reusable water bottle
- Appropriately-sized backpack — please check backpacks each evening for items to be removed or replaced
- Layers to accommodate temperature changes, during the day and between indoors and outdoors — natural base materials improve breathability and warmth
- Rain boots, pants and jacket (when raining or ground is wet)
- A hat appropriate for season
- Labeled sunscreen in warmer weather
- Mittens (plus extra pair) rather than gloves — fingers stay warmer when together
- Socks (plus extra pair); wool socks are best in cold or wet weather

PLEASE AVOID

Flip-flops, and open-toed shoes or sandals — they do not provide enough support, traction, and protection for play in our yards.

Indoor Clothing

The children sing, dance, stretch, jump, draw, paint, and help with a variety of classroom tasks. In order for your child to participate without hindrances in all our activities we ask you to provide:

- Clothing made of natural fibres when possible (more breathable, insulating and flexible)
- Layers for inside play as well
- Clothing that allows freedom of movement and independent changing (we suggest avoiding jeans and belts)
- Save makeup, nail polish, temporary tattoos, jewelry and watches for home

Items Needed from Home

- Indoor shoes to be left at school
- Extra clothes bag to be left at school: please provide a complete change of clothes for your child in a clearly labeled bag. Bags will be sent home to be refreshed. A sample extra clothing bag contains:
 - Full change of seasonally appropriate clothes
 - Two to three pairs of socks and underwear
 - Plastic bag
- Extra fleece or sweater to be left at school
- A full water bottle and lunch
- A backpack

We are pleased to have children bring in treasures from nature to share. These will be returned home. Toys, collections, books and other 'special' items are best left at home.

Electronics and Media

We understand that every family has their own approach to media, and we deeply respect those choices. Our intention is not to prescribe or judge, but to share the vision and the why behind the space we work to create: a space that fosters true imagination, connection and presence.

At Cedar Grove, we believe early childhood is a time for deep human connection, imaginative play and hands-on learning.

A central value of our program is to encourage children to access and develop their true imagination and creativity. By maintaining a school environment free from consumer and commercial influences, we help children more easily connect with and develop their own original ideas and imaginative play.

To help preserve a media-free learning environment, we ask families to share in our "media is for home, not school" approach and avoid sending media-related items (e.g. clothing, backpacks, water bottles, toys etc) with children. We will echo this approach in the classroom so that together we can create an environment where children can leave powerful media influences at the door and deeply enter their true imagination more readily.

It is our recommendation that families minimize or avoid screen use for young children, especially before and after school. As mentioned, we understand that every family has their own approach to technology. If you've found a screen use routine that works well for your household, that's wonderful. If you're interested in parent information nights pertaining to screen use in the home, let us know by emailing admin@cedargroveschool.ca and we'll work toward organizing a parent night to share ideas, strategies, and community support.

Communication and Culture

Healthy communication between parents/guardians, teachers, and the school community is important to all of us and vital to support learning and strengthen relationships. To facilitate productive communication, we suggest the following:

- Simple topics may be communicated via email or by giving the teacher a note at drop-off or pick-up
- At pick-up and drop-off times, teachers are supervising children and are unavailable at that time for in-depth discussions
- Please contact the Head of School by phone or in person if a more in-depth discussion is required
- Teachers respond to emails within 1–2 business days

Parent-School Communication

Honest, respectful, and timely communication is of utmost importance. We will contact you immediately if there are any concerns about the safety, development, or well being of your child. In turn, we encourage you to speak to us about your concerns or questions. Please inform us as soon as possible of any significant changes in home life or routine so that we can be sensitive to your child's needs.

If it is necessary to leave a message for a teacher or arrange changes regarding your child's routine, please email admin@cedargroveschool.ca.

Parent/Guardian-Teacher Conferences

Held in Fall and Spring, these provide an opportunity for strengthening the parent/guardian-teacher relationship, allowing your child's teacher to share observations about your child, and deepening the teacher's understanding of your child.

Report Cards

Report Cards are provided for students attending 4–5 days and are sent home twice a year.

Student Work

Student work remains at the school and is sent home at the end of each term.

School Newsletters

Newsletters are sent by email and written monthly. Please let us know if you are not receiving our communications.

We encourage parents/guardians to review the Cedar Grove School website www.cedargroveschool.ca and Instagram account [@cedargroveschool.pec](https://www.instagram.com/cedargroveschool.pec) for updated school events.

Where childhood grows naturally.